Chapter Fifty

The Mamluks of Egypt

Between 1250 and 1268,
the Bahri Regiment takes control of Cairo,
and the Mongols suffer their first defeat

In Egypt, mamluk soldiers now governed the country, and a woman sat on the throne.

After Turan-shah's murder, the Bahri Regiment had taken control of Egypt's government. Realizing that they had no legitimate claim to rule, its leaders had followed Islamic custom and recognized Ayyub's widow Shajar al-Durr as the new sultan; but the power of government remained firmly in their hands.

Shajar al-Durr had been one of Ayyub's younger concubines (Turan-shah's mother was long dead); she had apparently become one of his favorites, and later his wife. She had borne him a single son, Khalil, who died as a baby. As sultan of Egypt, Shajar al-Durr had coins struck in her name and Friday prayers said on her behalf, but not in her name alone. She represented herself, always, as "Queen of the Muslims and Mother of Khalil." Only as mother of Ayyub's son could she claim any right to hold the throne.[1]

And even this right was a shaky one. Hearing of the coup d'état and Shajar al-Durr's enthronement, the Abbasid caliph in Baghdad had sent a